

SERENGETI SAVANNAS

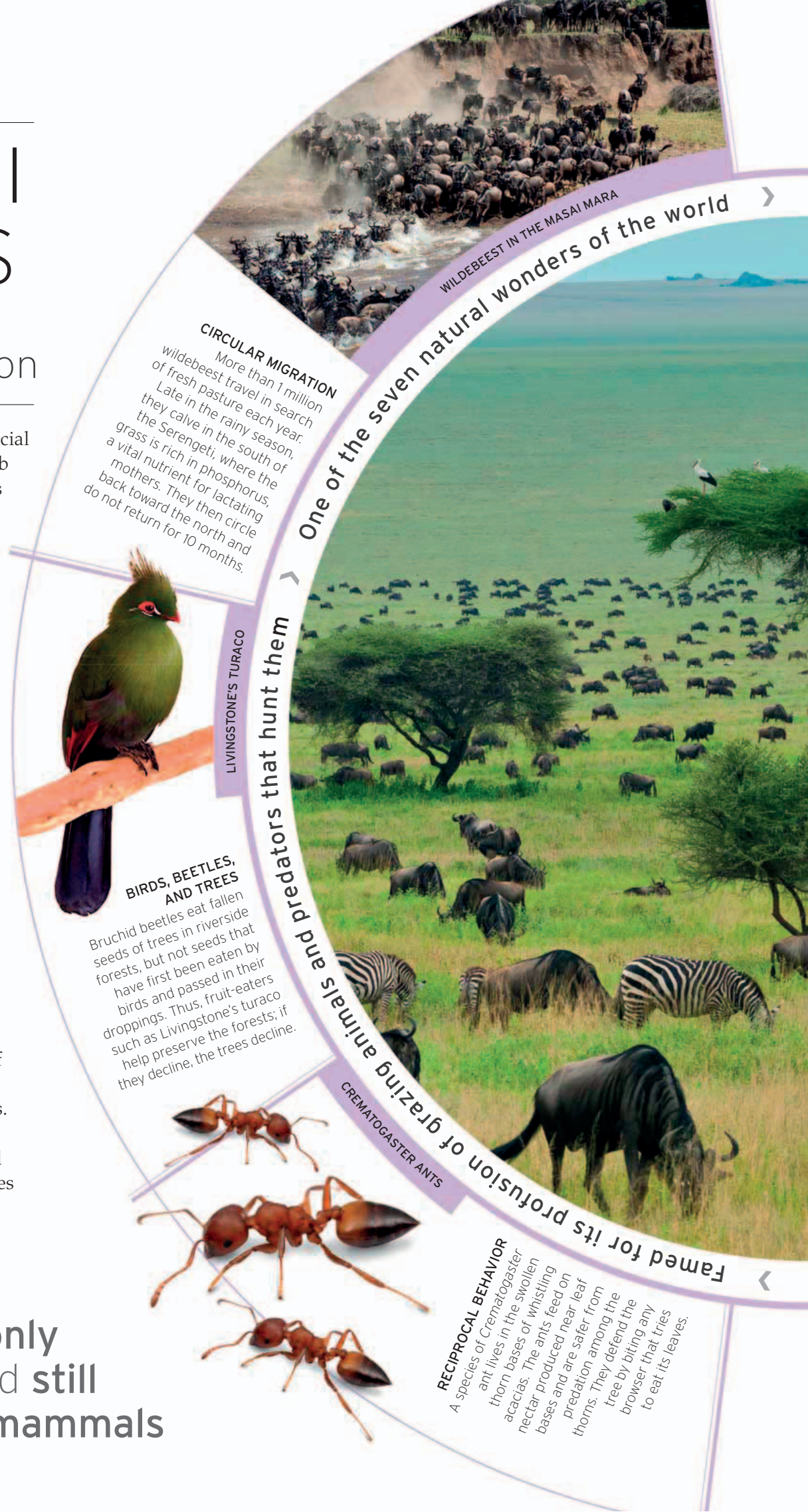
Home of the world's most famous migration

Grassland systems depend on natural or artificial factors that prevent natural succession to scrub and then forest. In the Serengeti, these factors are fire and grazing. This is a highly seasonal ecoregion, where the rain-induced growth of grasses such as red oat and couch grass supports vast herds of herbivores, which travel as the seasons progress, following the best grazing opportunities. When zebras, wildebeest, and Thompson's gazelles gather to migrate, their numbers seem uncountable and their movement unstoppable. Other significant species include elephant, giraffe, impala, and Cape buffalo. The herbivorous hordes support abundant predators and scavengers including big cats, hyenas, wild dogs, birds of prey, and vultures.

Changing but the same

The wildlife seen today is a fraction of that which existed 100 years ago. Human encroachment, mainly for agriculture, has greatly reduced the area of habitat available and this, along with hunting, has drastically reduced populations. Even so, the character of this ancient landscape and the cycles of life it shapes have changed little in millions of years. The land would be recognizable to the early humans whose remains have been discovered at sites such as Olduvai Gorge, which today lies within the Serengeti National Park.

The Serengeti is the **only** ecoregion in the world **still** dominated by large mammals



CIRCULAR MIGRATION

More than 1 million wildebeest travel in search of fresh pasture each year. Late in the rainy season, they calve in the south of the Serengeti, where the grass is rich in phosphorus, a vital nutrient for lactating mothers. They then circle back toward the north and do not return for 10 months.

LIVINGSTONE'S TURACO

BIRDS, BEETLES, AND TREES

Bruchid beetles eat fallen seeds of trees in riverside forests, but not seeds that have first been eaten by birds, fruit-eaters droppings. Thus, turacos such as Livingstone's turaco help preserve the forests; if they decline, the trees decline.

CREMATOGASTER ANTS

RECIPROCAL BEHAVIOR

A species of Crematogaster ant lives in the swollen thorn bases of the acacias. The ants feed on nectar produced near leaf bases and are safer from predation among the thorns. They defend the tree by biting the browser that tries to eat its leaves.

WILDEBEEST IN THE MASAI MARA

One of the seven natural wonders of the world

Famed for its profusion of grazing animals and predators that hunt them